CHAPTER 13

W A T E R, F U E L, A N D P O W E R

WATER

Water supply is at present the most important natural limitation on the ability of Palestine to absorb large numbers of new immigrants. As previously noted, there is no lack of water in the country. But the poor distribution of rainfall in time and area limits its effective use. Due to the maldistribution of water resources, the country needs an integrated irrigation program for conserving water in areas where it abounds and is going to waste and delivering it to other areas where and when it is needed.

The water for this purpose lies in the rivers, springs, and underground water bodies. The three rivers are: the Jordan and its tributaries, the Hasbani, Liddani, and Banyas; the Yarmuk, a tributary of the Jordan flowing only partly in Palestine; and the Yarkon (also called the Auja), a small river to the north of Tel Aviv which is under concession to the Palestine Electric Corporation. The Jordan is the largest river, having, according to government estimates, a flow of over 1 billion cubic meters per year at Allenby Bridge, a few miles north of the Dead Sea. Parts of this river are also under concession to the Palestine Electric Corporation. Local streams and springs are numerous near the source of the Jordan, in the Beisan Plain, the Jordan Valley, and in the Samarian and Judean hills. Water can be obtained also from wadis (the normally dry water-courses which fill up during overflow or floods) and from underground or percolated sources, At the present time underground percolation is the main source of water for irrigation.

In addition to these sources within the country, the Litani River, which flows entirely outside Palestine in the Lebanon, is also an important potential source of irrigation water. Before any part of the Litani waters can be made available for use in Palestine, however, an agreement must be made between the governments of the Lebanon and Palestine.